twin girls. The girls were two years old when my friend's wife was diagnosed with liver cancer. She died four months later, one week after her 28th birthday. My friend was devastated. If he had known he had a good chance of losing his wife when she was only 28, would he still have married her? Probably. But he would have been in a much better position to prepare for the future—and I bet he and his wife would have invested in a better life insurance policy and been very careful about saving for the future. As it happened, he was completely unprepared and had to raise two toddlers without a mother and on only one income. The loss of his beloved wife was excruciating, but when compounded with difficult financial situations, it very nearly tore him apart.

3. **Crushing debt**. It could be student loans, medical bills or credit card debt. The thing about debt is there isn't a hierarchy. There's no "good" debt and "bad" debt"—it's all horrific. If your due diligence reveals that your partner has significant debt, proceed with caution. How much debt you are willing to accept is up to you, but a good rule of thumb is that your partner should be paying down the principal every month and be working diligently toward a plan to pay off the debt completely. Draw a line in the sand and agree not to move in together or make wedding plans until he or she is making regular payments and reducing the principal. And each digit of debt should make your blood pressure rise accordingly. Four figures is manageable, if handled proactively. Five figures should give you pause. If it's in six figures, run while you can!
4. **Past bankruptcy or foreclosure**. This one should be obvious, but I'll spell it out for you just in case: *do not get into a relationship with someone who has declared bankruptcy or been foreclosed on*. Could you ask for better proof that your partner